Peppery watercress, curry leaf oil, and caramelized pear make a marvelous melange of flavors. The oil can be made a few days before and kept refrigerated.

spicy watercress soup

SERVES 4–6 **PREP** 20 MINS **COOK** 30 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 1 MONTH AT THE END OF STEP 2

3 tbsp fresh curry leaves
⅔ cup plus 2 tbsp olive oil
1 onion, chopped
2 medium potatoes, such as russet, chopped
1 quart (1 liter) hot vegetable stock
9oz (250g) watercress
salt and freshly ground black pepper
2 tbsp crème fraîche

for the garnish
1 pear, peeled and finely diced
2 tbsp confectioner's sugar
pinch of coarsely ground black peppercorns
1 tbsp crème fraiche

1 First make the curry leaf oil. Drop the leaves into a pan of boiling water and cook for about 30 seconds. Remove and refresh with cold water. Pat dry with paper towels and transfer to a blender. Warm the ⅔ cup oil and gradually pour into the blender as the leaves are being processed. Blend to a smooth paste. Line a sieve with a thin paper towel and pour the curry leaf mixture into it—the oil will slowly drip through.

2 For the soup, heat the 2 tbsp olive oil in a large pan and add the onion and potato. Cover and cook over low heat, stirring frequently, until softened but not colored. Pour in the stock and simmer for another 10 minutes, until the potatoes are cooked. Add the watercress and cook for another minute. Season with salt and pepper, and stir in 2–3 tsp of the curry leaf oil. Blend with a stick blender until smooth and sieve to remove any tough fibers.

3 For the garnish, toss the pear in confectioner's sugar seasoned with pepper. Cook in a heated frying pan until caramelized.

4 Reheat and re-season the soup and whisk in 2 tbsp of crème fraiche. Ladle into bowls, and top with an extra dollop of crème fraiche. Scatter the pears over the top and finish with an extra drizzle of curry leaf oil.